

Dowland was in Denmark from 1598 to 1606, when relations between England and Denmark were tense, especially on the issue of fishing rights. He was hired not only as a lutenist, but as a negotiator and messenger between the two countries.

A novel combination

The songs themselves were equally novel. Dowland blended elements from the madrigal, the consort song, and the broadside ballad to create exquisitely plaintive melodies. These display a bittersweet melancholy that was then highly fashionable, typified by titles such as “In darkness let me dwell” and “Welcome, black night” (a wedding song). Dowland published three books of his songs, along with the extraordinary *Lachrimae* (Tears, 1604). The latter features seven variations of his most famous song, “Flow, my tears.”

These books helped make Dowland one of the most famous musicians in Renaissance Europe. He was particularly successful as the court lutenist in Denmark, where Christian IV paid him an exorbitant salary. Dowland was never valued as highly in his homeland, although he did belatedly receive a royal appointment from James I in 1612.